Phubbing means looking at a phone during the group talk.

Start the 10-minute timer when someone first looks at their phone.

Disengagement scale:

0 = Looks but still talking normally.

1 = Short look. Small delay.

2 = Looks for a bit. Talks less.

3 = Long look. Not talking much.

4 = Very long look. Not talking at all.

Observation 1
Observer name: Azeez Abidemi Adigun Date: November 18,
Start time: 3:06pm End time: 3:16pm
Place: seventh floor of the library Group activity: Study talk
Number of people: 5

Episode	Start	End	Duration	Rating	Group Reaction	Notes
1	0.00	0.07	7s	1	✓ Interacted with phubber ☐ Ignored Phubber ☐ Looked at their own phones	Quickly look at phone then back to talk
2	1:40	2:05	25s	2	☐ Interacted with phubber ✓ Ignored Phubber ☐ Looked at their own phones	typing and missed joke
3	4:15	4:58	43s	3	☐ Interacted with phubber ☐ Ignored Phubber ✓ Looked at their own phones	long scroll and did not answer question

Observation 2
Observer name: Azeez Abidemi Adigun Date: November 19,
Start time: 2:22pm End time: 2:32pm
Place: Hungry Badger Group activity: Laughing and talking
Number of people: 4

Episode	Start	End	Duration	Rating	Group Reaction	Notes
1	0:00	0:10	10s	1	✓ Interacted with phubber ☐ Ignored Phubber ☐ Looked at their own phones	quick look at phone
2	2:20	3:00	40s	3	☐ Interacted with phubber ✓ Ignored Phubber ☐ Looked at their own phones	stopped talking and kept scrolling
3	7:10	7:40	30s	2	☐ Interacted with phubber ☐ Ignored Phubber ✓ Looked at their own phones	checking Phone, likely a text message

Observation 3
Observer name: Azeez Abidemi Adigun Date: November 18,
Start time: 6:17pm End time: 6:27pm
Place: Market food court Group activity: Eating and talking
Number of people: 4

Episode	Start	End	Duration	Rating	Group Reaction	Notes
1	0:00	0:05	5s	0	✓ Interacted with phubber ☐ Ignored Phubber	quick check but still talking

					☐ Looked at their own phones	
2	3:00	3:35	35s	3	☐ Interacted with phubber ✓ Ignored Phubber ☐ Looked at their own phones	long scroll and not joining
3	6:50	7:20	30s	2	✓ Interacted with phubber ☐ Ignored Phubber ☐ Looked at their own phones	checking phone and looking up sometimes
4	9:00	9:45	45s	4	☐ Interacted with phubber ☐ Ignored Phubber ✓ Looked at their own phones	fully on phone and silent

Part 2

Introduction

Phubbing is the act of ignoring someone in a social setting by focusing on your phone instead of paying attention to them. It is important to study phubbing among university students because when people focus on their phones instead of talking to their friends, it can hurt their relationships and make people feel lonely and left out. Understanding how often phubbing happens and what happens when it does can help us build stronger and healthier relationship. Therefore, the purpose of this study is to observe real groups of students in public places and count how many times someone looked at their phone during group time, measure how long they looked, and record how their friends reacted when it happened.

Method

Three separate 10-minute observations were conducted, for a total of 30 minutes of observation. Each 10-minute observation session involved a different group of at least 3 students who were socializing with one another or working as a group. Students who were sitting together but studying independently were not included in the study. The observation time started as soon as one student looked at their device. From that moment, that student was observed, with the following information being recorded: how many times the student looked at their device, for how long, and how much the student was disconnected from their friends. Being disengaged was defined as follows: A rating of 0 meant the student looked at their phone but still talked normally to the group. A rating of 1 meant a

short, quick look with only a small delay in talking. A rating of 2 meant the student looked at their phone for a bit and talked less. A rating of 3 meant a longer look at the phone without talking much. A rating of 4 meant the student looked at their phone for a very long time and did not talk at all to their friends.

The other students reactions were also recorded to know whether the other students: kept interacting with the phubber, ignored that student and interacted just amongst themselves, looked at their own devices, or did something else.

Results

Table 1 provides a description of the three groups of students that were observed.

Table 1

Characteristics of Observed Groups

Group	Date and Time	No. of people	Activity	Location of group	Location of Observer
1	November 18, 3:06 PM–3:16 PM	5	Studying, laughing and talking	Library, seventh floor group study area	Two tables away
2	November 19, 2:22 PM–2:32 PM	4	Laughing and talking	Hungry Badger	Nearby table.
3	November 18, 6:17 PM–6:27 PM	4	Eating and talking	Market food court	Nearby table

There was a total of 30 minutes of observation, 10 incidents of phubbing lasting a total of 4 minutes and 30 seconds were observed. Duration of phubbing for each group were as

follows: Group 1 had 3 incidents that lasted 75 seconds in total. Group 2 had 3 incidents that lasted 80 seconds in total. Group 3 had 4 incidents that lasted 115 seconds in total The extent to which the phubber was disengaged from their friends varied. In Group 1, disengagement ratings were 1, 2, and 3. In Group 2, disengagement ratings were 1, 3, and 2. In Group 3, disengagement ratings were 0, 3, 2, and 4.

The other student's reactions were recorded in all three groups. In Group 1, students continued interacting with the phubber, some ignored the phubber and interacted among themselves, and some of them looked at their own devices. In Group 2, they continued interacting with the phubber, some ignored the phubber and interacted among themselves, and some looked at their own devices. In Group 3, students continued interacting with the phubber, some ignored the phubber and interacted among themselves, and some looked at their own devices.

Discussion

This study found that phubbing occurred regularly among university students, with an average of one phubbing incident every three minutes across all observations. The phubbing behavior and group reactions were similar among all the observations**.** The data showed that phubbing was very common in all three groups observed. When one student looked at their phone, the group did leave them out. Instead, most groups continued their conversations while also using their own phone. All three groups showed the same pattern of reactions: some members continued talking to the phubber, some ignored the phubber and talked among themselves, and at least one other person also started using their own

phone. This suggests that phone use during social time is normalized and accepted among university students.

Looking at the different locations and activities, phubbing did not vary much. In the library where students were laughing and talking, in hungry badger where students were laughing and talking, and in the food court where students were eating and talking, the rates and patterns of phubbing were similar. This shows that phubbing is not just a behavior tied to specific places or activities, but rather a general part of how university students interact with each other. Phones seem to be treated as normal tools that can be used at any time, regardless of the the activity of place.

The disengagement ratings showed interesting variation. Most phone use was rated as level 1, 2, or 3 meaning students usually looked at their phones briefly or for a medium amount of time. However, in Group 3, one incident was rated as level 4, indicating complete disconnection from the group. This shows that while some phubbing is brief and does not disrupt group interaction much, sometimes students become so focused on their phones that they stop participating in the group entirely.

The group reactions showed a consistent pattern across all three observations. Other students did not seem bothered by phubbing. They continued to include the person on their phone in the conversation. At the same time, many other group members also pulled out their own phones. This creates an interesting cycle where one person's phone use leads to others using their phones too. This pattern appeared in all three groups, suggesting it may be a common response to phubbing among university students.

Two methodological weaknesses should be noted. First, the study did not identify what type of activity was happening on the phone—whether students were texting, checking social media, checking the time, or doing schoolwork. Different activities might have different impacts on group connection. Without knowing what students were doing on their phones, we cannot determine if brief time-checking is just as disruptive as scrolling through social media. This affects reliability because different types of phone use might need different measurements. Second, the observations were conducted on only three separate occasions, which may not capture all the different types of situations when university students gather together. The groups may not represent all possible types of student interactions, such as first-year students versus fourth-year students, or different cultures and backgrounds. This affects the generalizability of the findings because we cannot be sure the patterns we saw apply to all university students.

One methodological strength of this study was the use of a clear and consistent disengagement scale applied to all observations. By measuring both the frequency and the intensity of phone use using the 0-4 scale, the study captured more detailed information than simply counting phone use as yes or no. This gave us a more complete picture of how much disconnection actually occurred during each incident. The scale allowed us to understand not just that phubbing happened, but how much it affected the person's ability to participate in the group. This enhances the validity of the study because it measures what we actually wanted to understand—the degree of disengagement—rather than just yes-or-no phone use.

Conclusion

What surprised me most was how normal and accepted phubbing seemed to be. Nobody appeared upset or bothered when someone pulled out their phone. Friends just continued talking, and often they would pull out their phones too. It felt like an invisible rule that everyone follows without thinking about it.

This study showed that even small moments of phone use add up to big breaks in connection. Every three minutes, someone was looking at their phone instead of paying attention to their friends. These moments might not seem like much on their own, but over time they could affect how close people feel to each other and how supported they feel by their group.

The value of including a phubbing-related pledge in the CopeCareConnect initiative is that it makes us think about something we usually do without noticing. When we make a promise to put our phones away during time with friends, we are choosing to show that we value those friendships. If more students made this choice and kept it, it could help build the kind of strong, healthy friendships that help people feel less alone and more supported.

References

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